

Debt Help & Credit Counseling

Drowning in credit card or other debt? Free, trustworthy nonprofit counselors can help you build a plan, lower your interest, and deal with creditors — without the traps of for-profit “debt relief” companies. Tick the box once you’ve contacted each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Real nonprofit credit counseling is low-cost or free and never charges large upfront fees. Be very careful with companies that promise to “erase” your debt, guarantee results, or tell you to stop paying your creditors — those are the classic signs of a scam.

1 Free Nonprofit Credit Counseling

Certified counselors review your full situation for free and help you choose a path. Look for the NFCC network — member agencies don’t charge upfront fees.

☐ NFCC — National Foundation for Credit Counseling

The nation’s largest nonprofit credit counseling network. Connect with a certified counselor who works with you and your lenders.

→ www.nfcc.org

☐ Find an NFCC Member Agency

Search for a vetted nonprofit counseling agency near you or by phone.

→ www.nfcc.org/agency-finder

2 Lower Your Payments (Debt Management Plan)

A counselor may set up a Debt Management Plan (DMP) — one monthly payment, often with lower interest rates negotiated with your creditors.

☐ Ask About a Debt Management Plan

Through an NFCC counselor, a DMP can roll your debts into one affordable payment and may lower your interest. A safer, cheaper alternative to for-profit debt settlement.

→ Ask your NFCC credit counselor

3 Know Your Rights & Report Problems

Federal agencies protect you from abusive debt collectors and scams — and help you take action.

☐ CFPB — Consumer Financial Protection Bureau

Free help if a debt collector is breaking the rules, plus tools to understand your options. File a complaint online.

→ www.consumerfinance.gov/complaint

☐ FTC — Report Debt Relief Scams

Report companies that charge upfront fees, guarantee results, or impersonate the government.

→ reportfraud.ftc.gov

4 If You're Considering Bankruptcy

Sometimes a fresh start is the right move. Initial consultations with attorneys are often free, and required counseling is low-cost.

☐ Find Free or Low-Cost Legal Help

Legal aid offices can advise on bankruptcy and debt. Start here to find help in your area.

→ www.lawhelp.org

☐ Approved Credit Counseling for Bankruptcy

The required pre-bankruptcy counseling must come from a government-approved agency. Use the official list.

→ www.justice.gov/ust/list-credit-counseling-agencies-approved-pursuant-11-usc-111

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

If a company asks for a big fee before doing anything, “guarantees” it can wipe out your debt, or tells you to stop paying and stop talking to creditors — walk away. The FTC shut down a \$100M debt scam in 2025 that did exactly this.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Start with a free NFCC counseling session before signing anything. A good counselor will lay out all your options — including ones that cost you nothing — with no pressure to enroll.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Ask for your personalized debt-help search

This guide covers the main national, trustworthy starting points. For a counselor near you or help comparing your options, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we'll guide you.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
